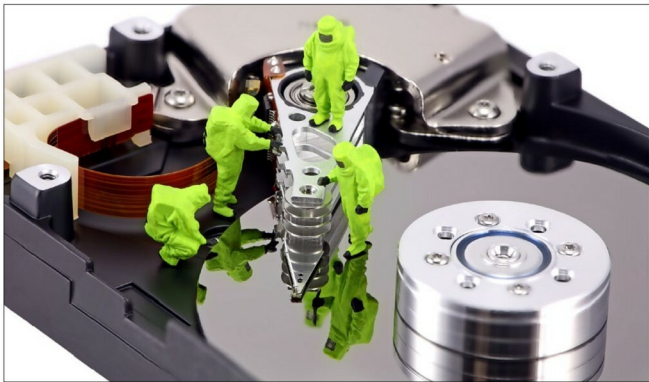


Recover the Files in Your Computer Without Formatting It!

Your computer has a problem and the only solution in sight seems to be formatting it. Before you take that drastic step and lose all your precious data and files, think of computer recovery as a solution. This article explores computer recovery without formatting.



Most computer users have faced some problems with the file system. Sometimes we accidentally delete system files or install programs improperly, which triggers the message ‘Oops! Couldn’t load the operating system’ while bootloading the next time. I myself have often faced such situations. Even experienced users have told me to format my hard disk and reinstall the OS. But if I had listened to their advice, I would have lost my valuable files and I couldn’t have written this article for you! So let’s see what tests and tricks we can try before considering a complete formatting.



Note: * ‘Disk utilities’ means graphical programs such as ‘Disk Utility’ or ‘gparted’, which allow you to handle disk partitions.

* In the upcoming sections, we use the prefix ‘sudo’ before commands, which gives us superuser privileges. Be careful — executing the wrong commands under ‘sudo’ can damage your system. If ‘sudo’ doesn’t seem to work, try ‘fakeroot’ or nothing instead.

The importance of a recovery disk

It is always recommended that you keep a recovery disk on your computer table since it is a necessary tool in many cases. A ‘recovery disk’ simply means a bootable disk such as a CD, DVD or a USB storage medium, which contains some recovery software. Live CDs of GNU/Linux distros (e.g., Ubuntu) can act as good recovery tools. TestDisk/PhotoRec bootable disks can also be used (we will explore both programs later). When we boot from a GNU/Linux live CD, the benefit is that we can handle the drives of other operating systems and perform a manual back-up. Executing recovery tools in a live CD is also simple and makes our task much easier.

I’ll recommend the use of an Ubuntu live CD (can be prepared by downloading and burning its ISO image from ubuntu.com) as the recovery disk. It would be great if you can set up a live USB disk, since it is fast and flexible.

Take a back-up!

The first step to be taken before ‘you damage your file system’ and the first task to be performed before the recovery